stationed in Along, would have merely acted as a post office to convey orders to Madiah. By 4 October, Lieutenant General Umrao Singh and with him HQ XXXIII Corps had handed over responsibility for NEFA to the newly founded IV Corps under the command of Lieutenant General Bijji Kaul.

So the question is who gave the order for 6 Kumaon to move to Kibithu? Both Kaul and Niranjan Prasad were embroiled in the events at Nam Ka Chu at this time and could not have given the order for 6 Kumaon's advance. Given the fact that the entire thrust at the time was 'to get a move on' and move forward to the Thagla Ridge and evict the Chinese, the order given to 6 Kumaon was issued in the same spirit of no regard for the actual ground conditions and in all probability originated from the BGS of the newly set up IV Corps, Brigadier K. K. Singh, who was trying to direct the battle from Tezpur.

The area ahead of Walong was being held by the Assam Rifles and Madiah and his battalion should ideally have remained in control of the defences around Walong. Had the Chinese pressed forward, the Assam Rifles platoons and A Wing would have fallen back to where the Kumaonis were waiting in prepared defences. Given the terrain and the narrow boxed-in terrain of the Lohit Frontier Division, regardless of the quantum of force brought to bear by the Chinese, they would have found Walong very difficult to approach, let alone capture.

Instead, Madiah was moved forward into relatively unfamiliar ground to take on the Chinese on the crest lines of the watershed itself. 4 Sikh, flying in and manning battle stations on features they did not know existed until they were physically standing on them, were equally at sea. The thoughtless decision to advance destabilized the entire sector to such an extent that it was almost impossible to recover. The advantage the Indians had as defenders in favourable conditions was squandered even before the first shots were fired.

Eventually, with no effective command and control set up, the ad hoc Kibithu garrison—6 Kumaon and the assorted platoons of 2 and 7 Assam Rifles—would exist in a vacuum. For a sector that was deemed to be as important as the Kameng Frontier Division, Lohit was treated in a most cavalier fashion.

On 18 October (two days prior to the Chinese attack on the Nam Ka Chu) a Kumaoni patrol noticed a Chinese party consisting of two officers